

The YEAR of FEAR

| By S. Prasannarajan |

Emotions churn and swell, anticipating the danger of the unknown. Every step becomes tentative, accentuating the uncertainty of the next moment. You are afraid, very afraid, and the worst looks imminent, real. Still, you are not without a choice, though limited. Either surrender to your impulses and let the situation unravel itself; close your eyes and see in that infinitesimal darkness a slideshow of your yesterdays. Or, let the force of life take you forward, and confront the inevitable. Fear envelops you like mist, brings you closer to yourself. In that instant, you see your own image—a convulsive portrait of exaggerated strokes. You have

never seen it before; you won't like to see it again. And the India that survived 2008 and lost a few heartbeats in the process would say, never again. Fear powered the year that ravaged the nation, and its story continues to be told in the sighs and sorrows of the living.

The story needs to be retold, for every telling is an act of remembrance. In 2008, fear rhymed with terror, and India was the site where they achieved a deadly symmetry. Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Delhi... and Mumbai as the flaming finale to a year that made gods and guns partners in hate. Radical Islamism got a new theatre of jihad and it was not another satanic citadel in the West or one of those hedonistic kingdoms in the desert. It was a country where life was cheap; it was India at its stoic best. Least resistant and most forgiving, we waited till the horror of Mumbai to realise the enormity of the Evil we were faced with. In the 60 hours that shook India, many certainties that kept us going for so long, no matter how much blood we shed along the way, were shattered, and made us aware of our vulnerability and fallibility as a nation. We were left with nothing but our fears—and a heap of ironies. As the victim, from behind the door in a luxury suite or in a crowded railway station, trembled in the fear of death, the killer feared nothing but his god. For the jihadi, death is a one-way ticket to a paradise full of fun. In 2008, there was no equality in the power of fear.

That was true of the fear of power as well. It took a controversial nuclear deal with America to bring out the conviction politician in our prime minister. It was the fear of

losing the deal, and thereby his chance to book a place in history, that forced him to declare freedom from the diktats of the commissar, still irredeemably steeped in the rusty rhetoric of anti-imperialism. He won the deal as well as the vote of confidence, and his tormenter lost the privilege of political harlotry: power without responsibility. The axis of fear in politics is power, not morality, though both the successful deal-maker and the failed deal-breaker may continue to talk principles. Such self-serving deceptions failed in 2008 to hide the dynamics of fear beneath the bravado of winners and the desperation of losers.

The number of losers is on the rise, united by fear, and they are not from politics alone. It was the year that saw the fall of "the masters of the universe". And capitalism was saved by the socialist instincts of governments in Washington and London. In a globalised world, fear too travels fast. The buzz of apocalypse in the marketplace has created a global, white-collar community of the fear-struck. Was 2008 the prologue to the Great Depression Part Two? Or was it just another evolutionary crisis in capitalism? Or, was Barack Obama its only beneficiary? The answers explain the intensity of fear that overwhelmed 2008.

Fear spawns change too; and in the other great democracy, it was "change we can believe in". It changed India too; at least our perception about a nation under permanent attack. Only the fear of conscience can make India the newest hope of national renewal. Let that be the narrative of 2009. ■